

TouchGrass

Business plan, revenue model and launch playbook

Log off. Pull up. · Hyderabad first, then South India

An app for meeting people in real life: small plans with your squad and friends of friends, safe by design, in English, Telugu and Hindi. The product is built; this plan covers how it earns, how it launches and what it needs to get there.

Version 1.0 · November 2026 · Confidential. All financial figures are planning assumptions, not results; they are stated in section 9 and should be revisited monthly against real data.

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1. Executive summary

What. TouchGrass helps people in Indian cities turn online connections into real plans: chai at a nearby cafe, a weekend trek, a board-game night, a run club. People plot small plans, pull up to their squad's plans, discover plans from friends of friends, and keep the memories (Lore and stories). Safety is built in: verified profiles, reliability scores, live location sharing and SOS, moderation, and mystery plans that hide exact places until shortly before.

Why now. Young professionals and students in fast-growing cities like Hyderabad are new to the city, work long hours on screens, and find it hard to meet people outside work. Existing tools are either built for dating, for big ticketed events, or for large anonymous groups. Nobody owns the small, trusted, last-minute plan.

How it earns. A 10% platform fee on paid plans (built and live in the product), partner-venue subscriptions, host boosts, an optional TouchGrass Plus membership, brand-sponsored experiences and corporate outings. Free plans stay free forever: they are the growth engine.

Launch. Invite-only beta in two Hyderabad neighbourhoods (Gachibowli and Madhapur), then a public Hyderabad launch in month 3, Bengaluru beta in month 8 (already set up as a beta city), Visakhapatnam on a waitlist.

Planning target	Month 12 (Dec 2027)	Month 24 (Dec 2028)
Monthly active users	22,790	71,390
Paid tickets / month	5,698	24,986
Ticket volume (GMV) / month	₹22.8 L	₹99.9 L
Revenue / month	₹6.7 L	₹22.9 L
Costs / month	₹19.3 L	₹30.8 L
Net / month	−₹12.6 L	−₹7.9 L

Funding need: about ₹3.26 Cr over 24 months in this model, with monthly break-even around month 33 (about 1.2 lakh monthly users). Recommended: raise in two steps, a pre-seed of ₹1.5 to 2 Cr to prove Hyderabad, then a seed round on real retention and revenue.

2. The problem and the opportunity

The problem

- Moving to a new city for work or study is common, and building a social circle there is slow.
- Plans die in group chats: nobody commits, the place is unclear, and people drop out at the last minute.
- Meeting strangers feels unsafe, especially for women; most apps offer no verification or accountability.
- Big-event apps sell tickets to concerts and shows, not the small everyday plans that build friendships.
- Dating apps are the wrong frame for friendship, and "friend modes" inside them stay niche.

The opportunity

A trusted, local, small-group plans app. The social graph is the moat: plans spread through squads and friends of friends, so trust and relevance come built in. Each plan creates more connections, each connection creates more plans. Paid plans, venues and brands monetise the activity without charging people to make friends.

Why Hyderabad first

- Large, young, migrant workforce in the IT corridor (Gachibowli, Madhapur, Kondapur, HITEC City).
- Dense cafe, food, sports and culture scene within short travel distances.
- Telugu, Hindi and English speakers, which the app already supports end to end.
- Founders on the ground, a smaller market to win before Bengaluru.

3. The product today

The product is built and tested (iOS, Android and web share pages, plus an admin console). Highlights:

Area	What exists
Plans	Plot a plan in a minute (what, where, when, who), free or paid, public, friends of friends, invite-only, women-only or balanced; mystery plans; +1s; waitlists; check-in at the venue; group chat (host can switch it off); comments under every plan.
Discovery	Ranked feed with reasons ("squad going", "nearby"), featured carousel, category tiles, themed rows (tonight, this weekend, solo-friendly), full-screen map, search.
Social	Squads (friends), contacts matching with hashed numbers, suggestions, activity, Free now with pings, crews (recurring groups), plan votes, stories (24 h, squad or friends of friends), Lore albums.
Safety	Selfie verification, reliability tiers and cooldowns, live location and SOS to trusted contacts, block/report, text and image moderation, sanctions, admin moderation queue.
Money	Razorpay checkout (UPI first), host payouts via Route, refunds by policy, receipts with GST, partner-venue perks with staff PIN.
Engagement	Badges, streaks with freezes, challenges, monthly recaps, referrals with passes and credits, notifications with quiet hours.
Platform	English, Telugu and Hindi; light and dark; accessibility (screen readers, large text, reduce motion); offline cache; multi-city admin with curators; privacy export and account deletion.

4. Who it is for

Persona	Who	What they want	How TouchGrass helps
The newcomer	22 to 30, moved for work, 0 to 5 friends in the city	Meet people like them without awkwardness	Solo-friendly plans, newcomer welcome, find-your-group signal at the venue
The organiser	Always the one making plans	Less chasing, more people actually showing up	Plot, invites, waitlists, reliability scores, reminders, group chat
The squad	Existing friend groups	Decide fast and do more together	Free now, plan votes, crews, stories, Lore
The host / creator	Run clubs, workshop leaders, community pages	Fill sessions and get paid	Paid plans, payouts, featured slots, analytics, crews
The venue	Cafes, studios, turfs, board-game cafes	Footfall on slow days	Partner listing, perks, staff PIN check-in
Women meeting new people	Safety first	Trust before turning up	Verified profiles, women-only plans, live location, SOS, mystery locations

5. Market size

Top-down sizing for the first two cities, using deliberately conservative planning assumptions. Replace these with surveyed numbers as soon as the beta produces them.

Layer	Definition	Planning estimate
TAM	Urban 18 to 35 smartphone users in India's top 8 metros who go out socially at least monthly	Several crore people; out-of-home leisure spend is a large and growing category
SAM	18 to 35 in Hyderabad and Bengaluru, working or studying, socially active	About 40 to 60 lakh people (assumption)
SOM (24 months)	Monthly active users in the plan	71,390 (about 1.5% of the SAM)

Revenue opportunity per active user is modest per month but compounds through frequency: a user who joins two paid plans a month at ₹400 generates ₹80 in platform fees a month before venue, brand and subscription revenue.

6. Competition and positioning

Alternative	Strength	Gap TouchGrass fills
WhatsApp / Instagram groups	Everyone already there	No discovery beyond your circle, plans fizzle, no safety or reliability
Meetup-style group apps	Large interest groups	Big anonymous groups, weak trust, little traction in Indian cities
Ticketing apps (District, BookMyShow)	Big events, payments, brand trust	Not built for small social plans or making friends
Dating apps with friend modes	Large user bases	Dating-first framing, one-to-one, not group plans
Social discovery apps (e.g. Ripple)	Modern social UX	TouchGrass focuses on real-world plans, safety and local venues in Indian cities and languages

Positioning: the easiest, safest way to make real plans with people you almost know. Small, local, trusted and multilingual.

7. Business model and revenue streams

Principle: **never charge people to make friends.** Free plans stay free; money comes from paid experiences, businesses and optional extras. We never sell personal data and never run ads that use it.

Stream	Status	How it works	Price (proposed)
1. Platform fee on paid plans	Built	Hosts sell tickets; TouchGrass keeps a fee (admin setting, default 10%) plus 18% GST on the fee; Razorpay costs come out of the fee; host gets the rest via Route	10% of ticket
2. Partner venues	Built (perks, staff PIN)	Venues list as partners, offer perks, appear on plans held there, get footfall reports	₹2,500/month after a free 2-month pilot
3. Host boosts / featured plans	Featured slots built (admin); self-serve to add	Hosts pay to feature a plan in the carousel or a themed row for 48 h, clearly labelled	₹199 per boost
4. TouchGrass Plus	To build	Optional membership: unlimited Free now pings, priority on waitlists, Plus-only plans, insights on your plans, profile themes. Never paywall safety, basic plans or seeing who saw your story	₹149/month or ₹1,299/year
5. Brand-sponsored experiences	Curated plans built	Brands fund curated plans (a run club by a sportswear brand, a tasting by a cafe chain); clearly labelled sponsored	₹50k to ₹3L per series
6. Corporate team outings	To build	Companies book curated small-group outings and new-joiner meetups; invoice-based	₹500 to ₹1,500 per head, 15 to 25% margin
7. Crew memberships	Crews built; billing to add	Recurring groups (run clubs, book clubs) charge a monthly member fee; TouchGrass takes the platform fee	10% of membership
8. Gift passes	Passes exist for referrals	Buy a pass for a friend's first paid plan; good for birthdays and onboarding gifts	Face value + fee

Suggestions to grow revenue

- **Start with fees and venues**; they need no new product and fit the launch. Add boosts once hosts see demand, Plus once retention is proven (month 6+).
- **Sell outcomes to venues**, not ads: "we filled 40 seats on your slow Tuesday" with check-in proof.
- **Bundle for brands**: a 4-week series in 3 neighbourhoods with Lore photos and recap stats beats a one-off.
- **Corporate onboarding**: HR teams in the IT corridor pay for new-joiner circles; this also brings new users.
- **Annual Plus** at a 27% discount improves cash flow and retention.
- **Do not do**: selling data, pay-to-message strangers, paywalled safety features, misleading "sponsored" content. Each would cost more trust than it earns.

8. Pricing and unit economics

One ₹400 ticket (as built)

Line	Amount	Notes
Ticket price (inclusive)	₹400	What the attendee pays
Platform fee (10%)	₹40	TouchGrass revenue
GST on fee (18%)	₹7	Collected for government, not revenue; charged on the fee only
Payment gateway (about 2%)	₹8	Absorbed by the platform from its fee (assumption: 2%)
Net to TouchGrass	₹32	Before infrastructure and support
Host receives	₹353	Via Razorpay Route after the plan, minus refunds

GST treatment and gateway rates must be confirmed with the chartered accountant and Razorpay contract.

Per active user (planning view, month 24)

Metric	Value	Assumption
Revenue per monthly active user	₹32	All streams combined
Cost per monthly active user	₹43	Team, marketing, cloud, gateway, legal
Blended acquisition cost (CAC)	₹80 to ₹150	Referrals, ambassadors and events; paid ads limited
Payback	6 to 12 months	Depends on 3-month retention (target 35%+)

The model works when people come back. The levers are retention (streaks, crews, recaps, Free now), plan frequency (more good plans nearby) and the share of paid plans, not aggressive pricing.

9. Financial plan (24 months)

Quarterly view of the monthly model. Revenue excludes GST collected. Costs include team, marketing, cloud and tools, payment gateway, legal and accounting, and overheads.

Quarter	MAU (end)	Ticket GMV	Revenue	Costs	Net	Cumulative
Q1 2027	3,000	₹1.4 L	₹0.1 L	₹33.0 L	−₹32.9 L	−₹32.9 L
Q2 2027	6,590	₹7.8 L	₹2.2 L	₹49.4 L	−₹47.2 L	−₹80.1 L
Q3 2027	13,190	₹23.1 L	₹8.6 L	₹52.6 L	−₹44.0 L	−₹1.24 Cr
Q4 2027	22,790	₹53.9 L	₹16.8 L	₹56.5 L	−₹39.7 L	−₹1.64 Cr
Q1 2028	32,020	₹92.1 L	₹26.2 L	₹78.6 L	−₹52.4 L	−₹2.16 Cr
Q2 2028	44,990	₹1.41 Cr	₹37.4 L	₹83.3 L	−₹45.8 L	−₹2.62 Cr
Q3 2028	56,670	₹2.00 Cr	₹51.1 L	₹87.9 L	−₹36.8 L	−₹2.99 Cr
Q4 2028	71,390	₹2.72 Cr	₹63.9 L	₹91.2 L	−₹27.3 L	−₹3.26 Cr

Revenue mix at month 24 (monthly)

Stream	Monthly	Share
Platform fees	₹10.0 L	44%
TouchGrass Plus	₹3.2 L	14%
Host boosts	₹1.4 L	6%
Partner venues	₹3.0 L	13%
Brand experiences	₹4.0 L	18%
Corporate outings	₹1.2 L	5%

Key assumptions

- Users: 300 in the closed beta, 3,000 at public launch (month 3), growth 30%/month to month 6, 20% to month 12, 12% to month 18, 8% to month 24; Bengaluru beta adds 1,500 in month 8.
- Paid tickets per active user per month: 0.05 at beta rising to 0.25 by month 12 and 0.35 by month 24; average ticket ₹400.
- Plus from month 6 (1% of users, rising to 3%); boosts from month 5; venues from month 4 (10 rising to 120); brand experiences from month 7 (1 to 4 a month); corporate from month 10 (1 to 6 a month).
- Team ₹6 L/month (beta), ₹10 L/month (months 4 to 12), ₹16 L/month (year 2); marketing ₹1.5 L to ₹8 L/month; cloud ₹70k + ₹4 per active user per month; legal and overheads ₹1.25 L/month.
- Extending growth at 6%/month after month 24 with flat costs, monthly break-even arrives around month 33 at about 1.2 lakh active users.

10. Go-to-market and launch playbook

Strategy in one line

Win one neighbourhood at a time with real plans every day, then let squads and friends of friends carry it to the next one.

Phase 0: before launch (now to December 2026)

- Company, bank, GST, DLT sender ID and SMS templates, Razorpay KYC and Route, Apple and Google developer accounts (these take weeks; start now).
- Privacy policy and terms reviewed by a lawyer (DPDP Act), grievance officer named, support email live.
- Recruit 30 founding hosts (run clubs, quiz masters, board-game cafes, trek groups, artists) and 15 partner venues in Gachibowli and Madhapur.
- Build a content calendar of 60+ plans for the first 4 weeks so the feed is never empty.
- Waitlist landing page with referral position; collect 2,000+ sign-ups through campus and office communities.

Phase 1: closed beta (months 1 to 2)

- Invite-only (invite gate on, codes per community), two neighbourhoods, 300 to 1,000 users.
- Daily founder-hosted plans for the first two weeks; weekly feedback calls with 20 users.
- Measure: plans per day, show-up rate, 4-week retention, time to first plan. Fix the top 5 frictions weekly.
- Ambassador programme: 20 campus and office ambassadors with invite codes, passes and recognition.

Phase 2: public Hyderabad launch (month 3)

- Launch week: 7 days, 7 signature plans (sunrise trek, Irani chai crawl, board-game night, run club, open mic, pottery, lake-side picnic) with partner venues and local creators.
- Press and creators: Hyderabad lifestyle pages and creators get early access and host plans, not paid posts.
- Referral push: both sides get a pass for a paid plan (built).
- App store: screenshots in three languages, ratings prompt after a good check-in.

Phase 3: deepen Hyderabad (months 4 to 7)

- Expand neighbourhood by neighbourhood (Kondapur, Jubilee Hills, Banjara Hills, Kukatpally); each needs 10 hosts and 5 venues before opening.
- Turn on venue subscriptions after the pilot, host boosts, and the first brand series.
- Corporate pilots with 3 IT companies for new-joiner circles.

Phase 4: Bengaluru beta (month 8) and beyond

- Repeat the playbook with a Bengaluru city lead and curator (multi-city admin is built); Visakhapatnam waitlist already collecting.
- Only open a city when its waitlist, hosts and venues meet the bar; a thin city hurts the brand.

Channels and budget split (first 12 months)

Channel	Share	Why
Community and ambassadors	30%	Highest trust, lowest CAC
Signature events and venue co-marketing	25%	Shows the product working in real life
Creators who host	20%	Content plus real plans, not one-off posts
Referral rewards	15%	Squads grow squads; built into the app
Paid social (tested)	10%	Only lookalike and retargeting once retention is proven

11. Operations: community, safety and support

Area	How it runs	Tools in the product
Moderation	Daily rota; held text and flagged images reviewed within 4 hours in launch weeks, 12 hours after	Moderation queue, holds, sanctions, audit trail
Verification	Selfie checks reviewed within 24 hours; verified badge needed to host	Verification queue (admin)
Safety incidents	SOS and serious reports escalate to the on-call lead immediately; police liaison process documented	SOS to trusted contacts, live location, reports
Host quality	Ratings, reliability, curator review of new paid hosts	Host applications, ratings, payouts on hold
Support	In-app and email, first reply within 24 hours; refunds by published policy	Receipts, refund engine, account export and deletion
City curation	City curators feature plans, approve hosts and keep the feed full	City-scoped admin roles, featured slots

12. Legal, compliance and policies

- **Company**: private limited company, PAN/TAN, current account; founders' agreement with vesting.
- **Data protection**: DPDP Act 2023 compliant privacy policy and consent; data stays in AWS Mumbai; in-app export and deletion (built).
- **IT Rules 2021**: grievance officer named and published; takedown timelines met by the moderation rota.
- **Payments**: Razorpay KYC, Route for host payouts, refund and cancellation policy page; host KYC before payouts (built).
- **Tax**: GST registration; GST charged on the platform fee; TDS/TCS obligations on marketplace payouts to be confirmed with the CA.
- **SMS**: DLT registration with sender ID and templates (OTP, safety alerts).
- **Age**: 18+ only (enforced at sign-up), stated in store listings.
- **Events liability**: terms limit liability for meet-ups; host responsibilities and community rules published; consider event insurance for large paid plans.
- **Trademarks**: file "TouchGrass" word mark and logo in relevant classes (software, events).

13. Team and hiring plan

When	Role	Why
Now	Founder / CEO	Vision, partnerships, fundraising, city launch
Now	Founder / CTO or lead engineer	Own the codebase, releases, reliability
Beta	Mobile engineer, backend engineer	Speed of iteration during beta
Beta	Community and partnerships lead (Hyderabad)	Hosts, venues, ambassadors, events
Launch	Trust and safety associate (part time to full time)	Moderation and verification queues
Month 6	Designer (product and brand)	Store assets, campaigns, product polish
Month 8	Bengaluru city lead + curator	Second city
Year 2	Growth/data analyst, sales for venues and brands	Revenue scale

14. Technology, cost and scale

The platform is built for production: NestJS API, realtime and worker services, PostgreSQL with PostGIS, Redis, S3 and CloudFront, all in AWS Mumbai with Terraform; Expo apps for iOS and Android; Next.js for web share pages and the admin console. Load-tested with k6; privacy, security and accessibility reviews are documented in the repository.

Cost item	Launch (per month)	Scales with
AWS (compute, database, Redis, storage, CDN)	₹40k to ₹60k	Active users and photo/video storage
Maps, SMS OTP, push, monitoring	₹15k to ₹30k	Sign-ins, searches, notifications
App stores and tools	₹10k	Seats
Payment gateway	About 2% of ticket volume	Paid plans

Estimates; confirm with the AWS calculator once real traffic exists. Video stories will raise storage and transcoding costs.

15. KPIs and how we measure them

KPI	Target (by month 12)	Where it comes from
Weekly active users / monthly	40%+	Analytics overview (admin)
Plans created per week per 1,000 MAU	60+	Events data
Show-up rate (checked in / going)	75%+	Check-ins, reliability
Time to first plan after sign-up	Under 7 days	Onboarding funnel
4-week retention	35%+	Cohorts
Share of plans that are paid	15 to 25%	Payments
Host repeat rate (hosts a 2nd plan)	60%+	Hosting
Safety: reports per 1,000 check-ins	Falling; all reviewed in SLA	Moderation queue
NPS after plans	50+	Post-plan feedback

16. Risks and mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Empty feed (cold start)	Launch one neighbourhood at a time; founding hosts; signature plans; curated plans from the team
Safety incident damages trust	Verification, women-only and balanced plans, mystery locations, SOS, fast moderation, clear incident playbook
Low show-up rates	Reliability tiers and cooldowns, reminders, waitlists, paid plans for committed groups
Hosts leave to WhatsApp	Payments, waitlists, discovery and reputation only work in-app; lower fees for top hosts
Big players copy the idea	Speed, local depth, multilingual product, trust and the squad graph
Regulation and tax changes	CA and lawyer on retainer; compliance built into the product
Running out of money	Staged raise; monthly review of the model; cut paid marketing first

17. Funding and use of funds

The model's cumulative need over 24 months is about ₹3.26 Cr. A staged plan reduces dilution and risk:

Round	Amount	Milestones it must reach
Pre-seed (now)	₹1.5 to 2 Cr	Hyderabad launch, 15k+ MAU, 35% 4-week retention, ₹5 L+ monthly revenue, Bengaluru beta started
Seed (month 10 to 12)	₹4 to 6 Cr	Two cities, 70k+ MAU, clear path to break-even, Plus and brand revenue proven

Use of pre-seed	Share
Team (engineering, community, safety)	55%
Launch marketing, events and ambassadors	25%
Cloud, tools, maps, SMS	8%
Legal, compliance, accounting	7%
Buffer	5%

Alternatives to equity at the start: founder funds and friends-and-family, government startup programmes (Startup India, T-Hub in Hyderabad), and revenue from venue pilots and corporate outings.

18. Roadmap

When	Product	Business
Months 0 to 2	Video stories (15 s), haptics, cover photos for demo plans, store assets	Beta, founding hosts and venues, DLT and payments live
Months 3 to 6	Self-serve host boosts, venue dashboard, notification tuning	Public launch, venue subscriptions, first brand series
Months 6 to 9	TouchGrass Plus, crew memberships billing, corporate booking flow	Bengaluru beta, corporate pilots
Months 9 to 12	Gift passes, smarter matching for solo attendees, recaps 2.0	Seed round, more neighbourhoods
Year 2	More cities and languages, partner APIs	Scale venues and brands, approach break-even

19. Product ideas to choose from

Pick the ones that fit the next milestone; each is sized roughly (S = days, M = 1 to 2 weeks, L = 3+ weeks).

Idea	Why	Size
Video stories (15 s)	Planned M4; stories with motion feel alive	L
Haptics on Pull up, likes, Ping	Small delight, premium feel	S
Cover photos for every plan (generated or from venue)	Photo-led cards look premium; empty gradients do not	S
Plan templates ("Chai at 6", "Sunday trek")	Plot in two taps	S
"Bring a friend" link for a plan	Viral loop through WhatsApp	S
Host dashboard with show-up and repeat stats	Hosts stay when they see results	M
Self-serve host boosts	Revenue stream 3	M
TouchGrass Plus	Revenue stream 4	M
Venue dashboard (footfall, perk redemptions)	Sells venue subscriptions	M
Crew memberships (monthly fee)	Recurring host income	M
Solo-attendee buddy match ("pair me with another solo")	Lowers the fear of going alone	M
Weather-aware suggestions (move outdoor plans indoors)	Fewer cancellations in monsoon	S
Plan check-in photo wall that becomes Lore	More memories, more sharing	S
Calendar sync both ways (busy times)	Better plan times	M
WhatsApp share cards with live seat count	Better invites outside the app	S
Corporate booking flow and invoices	Revenue stream 6	L
Kannada and Tamil	Bengaluru and Chennai	M
Smart reminders ("leave in 15 min" with traffic)	Higher show-up	M

20. Launch checklist (what a person must do)

From the repository's launch checklist (docs/LAUNCH_CHECKLIST.md); start the slow ones first.

- Incorporate, open a current account, register GST; name a grievance officer and support email.
- Lawyer-reviewed privacy policy (DPDP), terms, refund policy and contact page on the website.
- DLT registration and SMS templates; MSG91 account and keys.
- Razorpay KYC, Route enabled, live keys and webhook secret.
- Apple Developer and Google Play organisation accounts; store listings in three languages; privacy labels.
- Domain, AWS account with billing alarms, Terraform state, first deployment and bootstrap.
- Google Maps, OpenWeather, PostHog, Sentry and Expo push keys.
- Monochrome Android notification icon and Play feature graphic.
- Founding hosts, partner venues with staff PINs, moderation rota, launch-week plans.
- Production smoke test: sign-up, plot, pull up, chat, check-in, paid plan, refund, report, deletion.